

Tanks of the Communist Bloc

Soon after the end of World War II, the Soviet Union introduced the T-54. This was the first of a series of tanks that were produced in massive numbers and exported to the Warsaw Pact and Communist client states around the world. Soviet doctrine envisaged using tanks, supported by artillery and infantry, to break through frontline defenses and to make long advances into the enemy's rear positions. This influenced their design, which emphasized mobility and low height so that the tanks would be harder to hit. As a result, their crews usually found them cramped and uncomfortable.

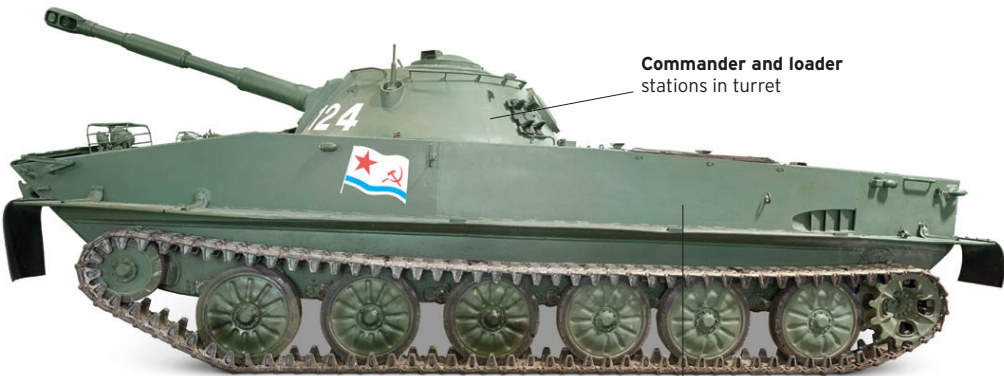


△	T-54
Date	1947
Country	Soviet Union
Weight	39.6 tons (36 tonnes)
Engine	V-54 V12 diesel, 520 hp
Main armament	100 mm D-10T L/53.5 rifled gun

The T-54 is one of the most produced armored vehicles in history. It moved away from Christie suspension, opting for torsion bars instead, and was armed with the 100 mm gun that proved its worth on the SU-100. The T-54 saw combat in Africa, the Middle East, Asia, and Europe.

▷	PT-76
Date	1951
Country	Soviet Union
Weight	16.1 tons (14.6 tonnes)
Engine	Model V-6 diesel, 240 hp
Main armament	76.2 mm 2A16 L/42 rifled gun

A light tank, the PT-76 was able to swim with the help of two water jets. This made it highly mobile and versatile, but its buoyancy requirements resulted in a large hull and thin armor that could barely protect the tank against heavy machine guns.



Commander and loader stations in turret

Light armor gives vehicle buoyancy



Extractor prevents propellant gases from entering the tank

100 mm L/53.5 rifled gun

Elongated hull

Spare track links

△	T-10M
Date	1952
Country	Soviet Union
Weight	57.3 tons (52 tonnes)
Engine	Kharkiv Model V-2-IS diesel, 700 hp
Main armament	122 mm M-62-T2 L/46 rifled gun

The last of the KV and IS line of heavy tanks, the T-10 had a short career, made obsolete by the development of the main battle tank. The Soviets used heavy tanks in independent battalions that were attached to larger units to provide extra combat power where needed. The last T-10s were withdrawn by the late 1960s, and replaced with the T-64.

▷	T-55
Date	1958
Country	Soviet Union
Weight	39.6 tons (36 tonnes)
Engine	V-55 V12 diesel, 580 hp
Main armament	100 mm D-10T2S L/53.5 rifled gun

Unlike the T-54, the T-55 had a Nuclear, Biological, Chemical (NBC) warfare protection system and a more powerful engine. Its production continued until 1981, with upgrades incorporating more modern systems, such as laser range finders and new sights. Many countries developed their own upgrades to keep it viable into the 21st century.